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Salesperson directive modification intention: a conceptualization and empirical validation

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Salespersons represent an important and challenging set of employees for organizational management. Given frequently high autonomy levels and varied job roles, boundary spanning agents have ample opportunity and motivation to modify/ignore organizational directives. Based on a multi-theoretical perspective, this research sets forth a three-dimensional conceptualization of directive modification intentions and develops and empirically tests a scale designed to better explain this phenomenon while empirically validating its occurrence. Results indicate that boundary spanners have three distinct and relatively stable motivations for modifying/ignoring organizational directives, including customer-, organization-, and self-focused motivations, and that each motivation may potentially relate differently to important antecedent and outcome variables. Managerial and theoretical implications are discussed.

Keywords: directive modification; salesperson; boundary spanner; scale validation; agency theory; cognitive dissonance

One of the most important functions of upper-level management in any organization is the formulation of corporate strategy. Strategies that are formulated at the top levels of the organization translate into functional directives focused on guiding and/or controlling the behavior of employees of the organization, particularly boundary spanning employees such as salespeople. Boundary spanners are a critical element for most corporate strategies because these employees have such a high level of interaction with important external partners (e.g., customers). The boundary spanner is frequently the face and voice of the organization to the outside world, managing several functions such as sales, post-sales service, and relationship management (Weitz and Bradford 1999). External partners with whom the boundary spanners work are vital co-producers of value with the organization (Vargo and Lusch 2004). The directives and controls of the organization are intended to guide boundary spanners in creating the right type and amount of value with the external partner. However, different controls have been shown to elicit varied reactions, both positive and negative, from sales employees (Miao and Evans 2014). Deviation from the directives of the parent organization by boundary spanners may result in a different value output from the interaction between boundary spanning employee and external partner, which may effectively point the organization in a new strategic direction that upper level management had not intended.

The very nature of the sales role compounds the difficulties associated with assuring directive compliance among salespeople. First, the boundary spanning function

typically necessitates a great deal of autonomy and flexibility, in spite of the potential for exploitation of such freedoms. For each goal that is laid out for employees either by the organization or individual, every employee may have a seemingly unique way of accomplishing it. Although management would likely prefer to monitor and control the boundary spanner in each of these tasks, this, for a number of reasons, is virtually impossible in most circumstances. The level of monitoring of such a subjective set of tasks would be extremely costly, to the point of being counterproductive from a profit standpoint. Also, controlling boundary spanners' actions would negate benefits to the organization derived from their intimate knowledge of the customer and industry, as well as potentially elevate the likelihood that employees engage in behaviors that do not optimally suit their unique skill sets. This is in addition to the negative motivational consequences that would stem from such a work condition. With this in mind, boundary spanners, particularly in business-to-business (B2B) organizations, are bestowed an unusually large degree of freedom in their job function, which creates the opportunity for information asymmetry between the boundary spanners and their parent organization.

In relation to either implied or specific organizational directives, there are situations where sales employees may deviate from an organizationally desired behavioral path. For example, Palmatier, Scheer, and Steenkamp (2007) recognize that salespeople may deliberately attempt to develop customer loyalty directed only to themselves instead of toward the company. Research also has considered the

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possibility that manufacturer's reps might identify more readily with a brand rather than their employer, which would influence their extra-role behaviors (Hughes and Ahearne 2010). In an example of behaviors inconsistent with specific directives, there is a stream of literature devoted to the organizational challenge of convincing salespeople to devote effort and commitment to the sale of new products or the adoption of new technologies (e.g. Atuahene-Gima 1997; Hultink and Atuahene-Gima 2000). Research also has examined cautiously granting autonomy and trust to boundary spanners by the organization, acknowledging that individuals afforded more latitude might exploit such opportunities (Perrone, Zaheer, and McEvily 2003).

Given all of this, it is critical for organizations to understand the machinations behind salesperson treatment of the directives issued by upper level management. With such contrasting information bases between upper level management and frontline boundary spanners, the appropriate expression of strategy as perceived by each will likely differ greatly. If boundary spanners perceive corporate directives to be misaligned with appropriate goals as perceived by the employee, then the individual will potentially engage in some form of modification of the directive to find a compromise between the two contrasting directions. This modification of directives from upper level management may therefore result in an unintended strategic malfunction by the organization as a whole.

The purpose of this research is to explore situations where salespeople may modify an organization's directives, creating both a conceptualization and empirical validation of the phenomenon. Previous research has highlighted the need for a better understanding of all parts of salesperson controls as part of an overall control system, including *employee response* to attempts to control behaviors (Flaherty, Pappas, and Lee 2014). Consistent with this, we seek to describe the phenomenon of directive modification and offer measures to empirically capture the intentions of boundary spanners to engage in directive modification, or the intent to alter/ignore the implementation of an organizational directive. We conjecture that, due to the complex nature of the sales role, boundary spanners are directly motivated to follow, modify or ignore organizational directives by more than just self-interests. Utilizing extant sales and organizational behavior literatures and informed by applicable theoretical perspectives, including dissonance and agency theories, we lay a foundation for understanding this intricate set of motivations in the context of the influence of the boundary spanner within the organization. Our exploration identifies various influences on boundary spanners to engage in the modification of organizational directives. Specifically, we posit that the individual boundary spanner is motivated by the interests of self, the external partner(s), and the employer. We complement this conceptualization with the development of scales to effectively measure the various motivations for salesperson directive

modification intention. Tests of such measures are provided and discussed, especially in relation to the role such measures may play within a sales-focused nomological network. Potential consequences and contributions of these findings are then discussed.

Directive modification

The term 'directive' has not been well-researched in marketing literature and has not been formally defined. In general, we propose that a *directive* is any guidance from organizational management directly communicated to the boundary spanning employee that is focused on altering some input of the boundary spanner's job function (i.e., altering a means to an end). A number of aspects of this definition are important to note. For the purposes of this research, we limit our consideration to only those directives that are explicit in nature. While we believe that directives can be implicit as well as explicit, the purview of this research is limited to only those that explicitly communicate the input of the boundary spanner that is to be altered. Further, it is in the context of explicit directives where research is more likely to have substantive impact on sales supervision and its consequences.

Additionally, as a specific order focused on an *input* of the job function of the boundary spanner, a directive is distinct from outcome controls, such as quotas for sales agents. Because outcome controls are objectively measured, they are rarely subject to the autonomy of the boundary spanner. As a basic example, consider an organization following a strategy to sell more of a given product in the coming period. The organization could set a quota for that product and instruct the sales force that all conversations with existing and potential customers must include mention of that product. The quota is not a directive under our definition. However, the instruction to mention the product to all customers is a directive because it addresses (and attempts to control) the inputs of the sales agent. Further, it should be noted that failure to comply with a directive can affect outcome performance, thereby influencing the firm's desired objectives and its capacity to measure the same.

In addition, a directive is directly communicated by organizational management to the boundary spanner. This precludes situations in which a boundary spanning employee learns of a directive by some means other than communication with the organization. Examples could include learning of a directive from an external partner or unofficial communication with other individuals inside the parent organization. Although these cases are rare, we explicitly exclude them from the current research because such circumstances would likely influence some of the relationships we will propose.

Following from this discussion, *directive modification* is defined as any behavior or behavioral intention by a boundary spanner that partially or wholly deviates from

the actions prescribed by his/her parent organization in its original directive. As such, modification behaviors or intentions can run the spectrum from full rejection of a directive (i.e., ignoring) to a slight alteration. Referring to our previous example, a sales agent engaging in directive modification could refuse to mention the product to any of his customers (full rejection) or 'forget' to mention it to just one of several customers (slight alteration).

One assumption is essential to establish for the current research and developing an effective means of measuring a salesperson's intention to engage in directive modification; we assume that there is at least some dissension by the boundary spanning agent with respect to the directive introduced by organizational management (i.e., a level of dissonance within the salesperson must be created, which would not be the case for an aligned or agreed upon directive – Bacharach, Bamberger, and Sonnenstuhl 1996). Hence, directive modification is inherently a modified path taken by a salesperson relative to an initial directive.

Directive modification versus similar concepts

In the marketing and sales literature, there are some fields of investigation that help to inform the current research, but they do not capture a salesperson's motivation for directive modification. Thus, marketing and sales organization's ability to implement specific directives, gauge boundary spanner responses to the directive and ultimately measure directive effectiveness to date has not received much needed attention in the literature

An emerging topic in boundary spanner research is that of deviant behavior. This topic has been examined in the management literature for some time, but has only recently been investigated in the unique context of the sales force. The broad topic of deviance in the workplace has been identified under various labels, such as organizational resistance (Lawrence and Robinson 2007) and anti-citizenship behaviors (Ball, Trevino, and Sims 1994), among others. The generally accepted definition of workplace deviance is, 'Voluntary behavior that violates significant organizational norms and in so doing threatens the well-being of an organization, its members, or both' (Robinson and Bennett 1995, 556).

One important point that is made throughout the literature on workplace deviance is that the definition directly identifies that the employee is engaging in behaviors in violation of organizational norms. This focus on violating behaviors is a critical distinction from the more overarching notion of unethical behavior (as well as from the current discussion of directive modification intentions, to be discussed subsequently). Unethical behavior is a violation of universally held right and wrong, but workplace deviance, directive modification, and similar constructs delineate a specific focus of the behavior (or behavioral intention), which may or may not be related

to right and wrong. So, a boundary spanner can engage in workplace deviance but not unethical behavior if the violated organizational norm is deemed unethical. In a similar fashion, directive modification research is distinct from the ethics paradigm in that directive modification focuses on a specific organizational instruction instead of universal right and wrong. If an organization issues a directive that is unethical, the more ethical choice for a boundary spanner may be to modify/ignore the directive. Clearly, directive modification could have ethical implications and outcomes. However, it must be treated as a separate research stream from ethics, and the ethical repercussions fall outside the scope of this research.

In addition, while there are some similarities and overlap between directive modification and workplace deviance, the differences are acute and require a new conceptual formulation to properly explore the phenomenon proposed in the current research. Jelinek and Ahearne (2006) discuss four salient points regarding the definition of workplace deviance: (1) the behavior is committed by members of the organization, (2) this behavior is voluntary, (3) organizational norms are the focus of the violation, and (4) the violations have a significant and negative impact because the behavior threatens the organization and/or its members in some way. In contrast to workplace deviance, directive modification violates specific directives of the selling organization, *regardless of their compliance with organizational norms*. So, as with the distinction with unethical behavior, this difference in the target of directive modification behavior creates a distinctly different research situation and questions. Also, directive modification does not necessarily threaten the well-being of the organization or its members. In fact, a boundary spanner engaging in directive modification may benefit the organization and its members (especially from his/her perspective, which suggests *intent* would possibly be different in directive modification versus deviant or unethical behavior). So, despite some overlap in relevant behaviors, directive modification and workplace deviance are conceptually distinct, requiring a separate measurement.

Finally, Malshe and Sohi (2009) directly address the notion of 'buy-in' from the sales department. 'Buy-in' is the closest concept in the literature to directive modification because it is applied to a specific marketing initiative. Although the concept of buy-in is similar to directive modification and reinforces the need for research in this general domain, there are significant differences between the concept of buy-in, as it currently exists, and directive modification. Malshe and Sohi (2009) define 'buy-in' as, 'The sales function's belief that a proposed marketing strategy or initiative is appropriate and has merit' (208). From the definition, buy-in refers to an effective response from sales employees that is not linked to specific action or intention. The current research goes beyond just the belief of the sales force (or any other boundary spanner) to

consider measurable intentions that individuals form. So, whereas buy-in is more affective in nature, directive modification focuses on a cognitive response by boundary spanners necessarily formed by a dissonant reaction (which could not be a needed avenue for buy-in), which is linked to a behavioral intention.

Theory

Two key theories guide our investigation of salesperson directive modification: agency theory and cognitive dissonance theory. Cases where employees resist managerial guidance (and attempts to control behaviors) fit the textbook definition of an agency theory problem. Agency theory is concerned with situations in which a principal (employer) and agent (employee) have conflicting interests (Eisenhardt 1989; Fama 1980), in a manner similarly represented by the dissonance created through misaligned logic for organizational action (Bacharach, Bamberger, and Sonnenstuhl 1996). One critical assumption in agency theory is that there exists information asymmetry between the principal and agent (Eisenhardt 1989). Not only do the two parties have differing information, they have disparate filters through which new information is interpreted based on their information contexts. These interpretive mechanisms can create the motivation for modification of directives from upper-level management by the frontline employee as s/he seeks to rectify new information into the existing work perspective as a means of retaining job satisfaction.

Another important assumption of agency theory is that the behavior of the agent is guided by self-interests (Eisenhardt 1989). The tendency within much of the extant literature has been to adopt this notion when considering employee deviation from managerial direction. However, an emerging stream of research has begun to question this implicit assumption of self-interest motivation. For example, some authors have explored 'organizational expedience' in employees (Parks, Ma, and Gallagher 2010). Also, pro-social rule breaking explores occasions where employees supersede organizational rules in an attempt to help, not harm, their organization (Dahling et al. 2012; Morrison 2006). Even in this emerging research, though, the unique job function of the boundary spanner has yet to be considered through this new lens.

The current research challenges the blanket application of the agency theory assumption that divergent behavior by boundary spanning employees is driven exclusively by self-interest. Our challenge to this assumption in the current research context is not that it is invalid. Rather, we posit that the self-interests must be pursued indirectly by boundary spanners in many instances through the interests of other essential parties, with the notion of integrating the interests of both the self and others also being consistent with

dissonance theory (Bacharach, Bamberger, and Sonnenstuhl 1996).

Cognitive dissonance forms the core of directive modification intention. Cognitive dissonance is a psychological state that refers to the discomfort felt between what individuals already know or believe and new information that is presented to them (Festinger 1957). As has been investigated in organizational theory, employees search for consistencies in the logic of action across organizational levels (i.e., institutional (corporate), managerial, technical (employee)), with changes recommended (or demanded) from the corporate and/or managerial level often being at odds with perceptions and motivations of employees (Bacharach, Bamberger, and Sonnenstuhl 1996). Such inconsistent views may be triggered by employee exposure to new information from managers, disagreement with such information, or because of forced compliance with organizational directives with intent to control behaviors (Bacharach, Bamberger, and Sonnenstuhl 1996). The end result of an inconsistent view is an employee's experience of dissonance in reaction to the organizational information and/or directive, and intentions to resist the change (Bacharach, Bamberger, and Sonnenstuhl 1996; Burnes and James 1995). Further, the experience of dissonance occurs *after* the exposure to new information has taken place, but *before* attempts at dissonance reduction have taken place, helping to form *intentions* to reduce such feelings (Bawa and Kansal 2008).

Motivations for directive modification

Considering the role of boundary spanners within an organization and the extant literature, three major potential dimensions of the motivations for directive modification would be the triangulation of the salespeople's perspective of the possible impact of a directive on their firm, themselves and their customer. Any one of these may be a possible source of directive modification. Hence, three sources of directive modification that are likely to be most prevalent include: customer-focused directive modification (CFDM), organization-focused directive modification (OFDM), and self-focused directive modification (SFDM). Customers are often researched as a source of role stress (e.g. Schmitz and Ganesan 2014), and the individual interests of salespeople have been considered a potential source of conflict (e.g. Darrat, Amyx, and Bennett 2010). While not as heavily researched, the organization itself also has the potential to create role conflict (e.g. Fournier et al. 2013). We posit that at least one of these areas may create dissonance for a boundary spanner when s/he disagrees with a directive aimed at controlling behavior received from her/his organization, motivating directive modification intentions. Such motivations are not mutually exclusive, so more than one motivation may be present, creating the motivation set for the boundary spanner. In the

following sections, we discuss and argue for the inclusion of each of these dimensions among intentions for directive modification.

Customer-focused directive modification

When considering the interests of an external partner, boundary spanners may be motivated to modify organizational directives as a means of fulfilling a desire (perceived or genuine) of the external partner to persist with the current business arrangement. Agency theory assumes agents to be risk averse (Eisenhardt 1989; Fama 1980). This risk aversion often can be connected with reluctance by boundary spanning employees to embrace change (Ahearne et al. 2010; Davis, Bagozzi, and Warshaw 1989). Additionally, bounded rationality is assumed for all parties. In the absence of information to the contrary, individual boundary spanners are likely to assume that external partners share in their risk aversion and would therefore be opposed to voluntarily engaging in actions that alter the existing status quo. In the interest of assisting the external partner in achieving this assumed common goal, boundary spanners will be inclined to consider engaging in directive modification.

In addition, some directives by the parent organization may be ill-timed for an external partner. Even if the boundary spanner is willing to embrace a directive, full acceptance of that directive may have to be shelved in the short term because doing otherwise would imply a disregard for the partner's situation, injuring the relationship. For example, an external partner currently engaged in a major software overhaul would be unlikely to agree to simultaneously transition additional software applications tied to the partnership with the boundary spanner's organization. With trust from the partner being so valuable, boundary spanning employees may be understandably averse to taking actions that could violate and/or decrease the partner's trust in the future. Thus, they may seek to modify directives that threaten to damage the relationship between the boundary spanner and the partner.

Additionally, the current job function of boundary spanners can lead to a consultative role for the employee with respect to the partner that can be quite critical to the success of the relationship (Spiro, Rich, and Stanton 2008). Sales consultants, for example, create value for customers by focusing on the discovery of latent needs and the optimal fulfillment of those needs (Pelham 2009). In this role of consultant, therefore, the boundary spanner advises the external partner on how to more efficiently and effectively conduct its business. In the pursuit of fulfilling the needs of the external partner, boundary spanners will necessarily filter out those ideas and actions that will not meet that end goal. As a result, a boundary spanning employee may be willing to modify/ignore a directive if it is inequitable for the customer in order to maintain or even strengthen the

perceived trust in the relationship. What the employer perceives as beneficial for external partners may not be perceived that way by frontline employees because of their different knowledge and familiarity with the situation (and the potential uniqueness of a given context), creating the previously noted feelings of cognitive dissonance. Also, the parent organization may deem it a reasonable exchange to experience a negative impact on the relationship with the partner in order to fulfill some other goal that will hopefully garner greater positive results for the parent organization or the entire relationship (a view that may not be shared or even appreciated by the sales employee).

Organization-focused directive modification

At times, the parent organization may introduce a directive that boundary spanners believe is not feasible and will cast both them and their organization in a negative light in the eyes of other participants in the industry. Such an inconsistent view will likely generate dissonance and the boundary spanner will be motivated to prevent such an occurrence. Even though the organization may be willing to accept less-than-optimal performance in the short-term in the interest of long-term growth, the boundary spanning agent may view the approach as a threat to immediate customer satisfaction/transaction quality. For example, a supplier may introduce a new product offering with the understanding that they are not fully prepared for every question or concern of their customers. In this case, organization's management considers this to be part of the reasonable costs of a new product introduction. Salespeople, on the other hand, may be reluctant to allow their company to fall short of what they hold to be acceptable performance standards with their customers. Salespeople may, in turn avoid discussion of the new product if they realize their customers will have concerns the organization is not prepared to address, opting to wait until a later time when the supplier is better able to fully meet its standards of performance.

We propose that this motivation to modify organizational directives represents a counterintuitive form of organizational citizenship behavior. Because of the unique aspects of their role in the organization, boundary spanning employees are posed with 'exception-to-the-rule' situations where their own discretion must be applied. Organizational citizenship behavior (OCB) is voluntary behavior by individuals that is outside the normal role of the employee and supports the organization (Organ 1988). Two dimensions of OCB relevant to the current research are organizational loyalty (commitment) and individual initiative (Podsakoff et al. 2000). Organizational loyalty includes behaviors aimed at defending the organization's reputation and promoting the organization as effectively as possible to external entities (Graham 1991; Moorman and Blakely 1995). Individual initiative entails performing functions above

and beyond the requirements of the prescribed job role (Moorman and Blakely 1995).

When a directive seems to contradict boundary spanning employees' desire to express organizational loyalty, their individual initiative, along with the accompanying feelings of dissonance, may motivate them to modify the directive. In such an instance, employees must choose between complying with the directive and effectively representing the parent organization to external parties. Since many boundary spanning job functions, such as sales, focus on short-term results (Homburg and Jensen 2007), these employees can confront situations where they may need to choose between what may appear to be disparate options. In these circumstances, salespeople may be motivated to modify directives which in their opinion are disruptive to their and their organization's customer relationships.

Further, the internal departments within the parent organization represent an often unconsidered set of vital partnerships for boundary spanners. As suggested by organizational theory, successful employees not only build relationships with external partners, but they also cultivate interactions with individuals and groups within their own organization (Plouffe and Barclay 2007; Steward et al. 2010). We propose that these internal relationships also provide motivation for boundary spanners to engage in OFDM.

When an organization develops a new strategy, the resulting directives rarely apply only to boundary spanners. Either through direct communication with other departments or conjecture on the boundary spanner's part, boundary spanners likely project how the directive issued to them may also affect other groups within the parent organization. How the directive affects these other groups can influence the boundary spanner's directive modification behavior. A boundary spanner may be motivated to preserve and foster relationships with internal members of the parent organization in other departments. If accepting a directive will create unwelcome challenges for their internal partners, boundary spanners more likely will be motivated to seek out modified versions of the directive.

Additionally, boundary spanners may seek to create indebtedness from internal partners by deviating from the directives. The norm of reciprocity suggests that when one partner in a relationship acts in the interest of the other partner, that other partner will feel an obligation to reciprocate such deeds (Rhoades and Eisenberger 2002). By 'bending the rules' for an internal partner, boundary spanners can create an atmosphere where the partner feels obligated to respond in kind in the future. Therefore, boundary spanning employees may be motivated to engage in directive modification behavior in order to prevent inequities for their partners within the parent organization.

Self-focused directive modification

Often a pervasive motivation for boundary spanners in a sales role is the financial. This motivation is frequently tied to a desire to expend the least amount of effort for a given compensation level, which can be referred to as job task minimization. For some boundary spanners (not necessarily limited to salespeople), this motivation is manifested as a basic desire to expend no more effort than is required to minimally meet the requirements of the directive. For others, though, this can become a complicated calculation because many boundary spanner rewards are based on their performance (i.e. commissions and bonuses) instead of effort alone. Here the implications of directives that may endanger existing business or redeploy customer purchase behaviors may have less than desirable salesperson compensation outcomes resulting in directive modification becoming potentially highly relevant.

Vroom's (1964) expectancy theory poses workforce motivation as a three-part equation. Employees will be motivated if three elements are present: expectancy, instrumentality, and valence. Expectancy is the belief that effort leads to performance. Instrumentality is the belief that performance leads to reward. Valence is the belief that the reward leads to satisfaction or that the reward is desirable. If these connections are not inherent when deploying a new directive, modification, in many cases, most likely will occur.

With few exceptions, the introduction of a directive by the employing organization disrupts at least some part of this set of equations for boundary spanners, likely prompting the feelings of dissonance that accompany change, especially when an employee has a strong belief that current methods of doing things are working well (Dechawatanapaisa and Siengthai 2006). Embracing a new directive from the parent organization requires effort from the boundary spanner. So, assuming some steady state amount of overall effort from the agent, a new directive will most likely lead to less performance directed toward other tasks (e.g., selling other non-directive related products/services or customer follow up). These modifications in task deployment ultimately could decrease existing rewards and possibly job satisfaction for the boundary spanning agent. If, however, boundary spanners can modify the directive, thereby making it more aligned with accommodating their core activities, their present rewards are maintained potentially with complete or, at best, partial compliance with the initial directive.

Some directives (e.g. software adoption or a refined job process) are designed to improve boundary spanner efficiency in the long-term. However, research indicates that boundary spanning agents tend to have a rather short-term orientation with some aspects of their job function (Homburg and Jensen 2007; Rouzies et al. 2005). Agency theory assumes bounded rationality for individuals suggesting

that the benefits associated with directives that fall outside that individual's typical cognitive framework are unlikely to be embraced. Unfortunately, from an organizational perspective, this short-term focus creates challenges for longer-term strategies directed at improving firm, salesperson, and client well-being.

Agency theory also asserts that the agent is risk-averse and the organization is risk-neutral (Eisenhardt 1989). So, even in the face of prospective future gains tied to the directive, boundary spanners could still be strongly motivated to engage in directive modification because there is a risk that the promised long-term gains may never materialize (and typically not during the period the salesperson is likely to experience material losses). This result could potentially leave the employee incurring a short-term loss in order to comply with a directive. Alternatively, boundary spanners might seek a modified version of the directive, thereby permitting them to protect their current outcome state and/or minimize the risk of loss. In contrast, the organization as a risk-neutral entity, selects actions that may pose some level of risk placing the boundary spanner in a vulnerable position. It is this conundrum, of firm risk propensity and agent desire for status quo, where the potential for salesperson directive modification is cultivated.

Methods

Given the strength of conceptual evidence regarding the existence and form of directive modification intentions among sales personnel, the next step in investigating this phenomenon is to develop a means of capturing its occurrence. In this light, a series of studies were conducted to develop measures for directive modification intentions in relation to each of the three dimensions previously detailed. Study 1 attempts to validate the identified dimensions of directive modification intentions through qualitative interviews. Study 2 describes item generation and scale purification. Study 3 was conducted in three stages, all using the same data-set: (1) initial item testing; (2) confirmatory analysis and validity testing; and (3) a nomological testing of the developed scales based upon construct relationships suggested by dissonance theory.

Study 1: proof of concept

This research generally follows the guidelines set forth by DeVellis (2003) in the development of a valid measurement scale. Once the definition and dimensions of directive modification intention were developed (as developed in the previous sections), the next step is to verify the conceptualization through qualitative interviews.

Eight personal in-depth interviews were conducted with sales professionals in different industries (see Appendix 1 for interview script). The panel of interviewees consisted

of personal contacts of one of the authors, supplemented by candidates for the advisory council of a large university in the Central USA. The panel included one female and seven male respondents. All respondents had at least five years of B2B selling experience with titles ranging from salesperson to vice president of global sales to CEO. Multiple industries were included to get a survey of various sales situations in our sample. Industries included pharmaceuticals, insurance, and home improvement products, among others.

Using a deductive approach, a semi-structured interview format was employed allowing for the detailed exploration of particular responses. Individuals were asked to share personal examples (i.e., themselves or other employees they observed) of instances when salespeople did not comply with employer directives, including their (the salesperson's) perceived motivations. Respondents were not provided direction with their responses, and were not 'led' toward any of the motivations for directive modification suggested by the literature. All of the interviews were audio recorded and lasted approximately 30 minutes. A transcript of each interview was content analyzed by a single coder. In particular, the coder investigated each interview for presence of the concept of directive modification as well as the potential cause(s) of the behavior. Table 1 summarizes the notable findings from these interviews.

Striking about the interviews was that the sales professionals could readily offer multiple stories of this phenomenon, with 'protection of the customer' being a consistent theme of examples. In addition, there was no trepidation or indication of social desirability bias preventing respondents from being forthcoming about this behavior. This phenomenon and its distinct dimensions seem to be very prevalent and considered to be normal behavior by all of the interviewees. Two of the respondents failed to indicate they altered the directives of their organization. Both individuals, however, later shared stories of modification behaviors during the interview.

Study 1 strongly indicates the existence of this phenomenon, along with the 3 distinct dimensions we have proposed (with no consistent theme of alternative motivations being exhibited). Further, Study 1 results are indicative of the applicability of dissonance theory, as more than one respondent noted that if s/he was involved with the development of the directive, s/he was much more likely to 'go along' with the directed change in actions, where such employee involvement has been demonstrated to reduce feelings of dissonance and subsequent resistance to organizational change (Burnes and James 1995).

In relation to CFDM, respondents were particularly motivated to protect their customers. 'It doesn't matter who I work for, (Company X) will always be my customer.' Hence, directive modification in the interest of protecting customers was both evident in our interviews and

Table 1. Qualitative study findings.

General findings	• Each interviewee was readily able to provide stories of times that either they or other coworkers had engaged in directive modification. • Two of the participants claimed that they did not believe they had the right to engage in directive modification. However, one of those respondents did have a story of an occasion when he modified an organization's directive because 'it wasn't right.' • Salespeople will often actively and openly try to find ways around a directive if it seems to have a negative impact on efficiency with respect to the situation before the directive. • Salespeople are often resistant to a directive if they do not see the benefit/purpose for it. • Salesperson involvement in the directive decreases the likelihood of modification.
CFDM-related findings	• Modification occurs if the directive threatens some kind of injury to the customer. • 'It doesn't matter who I work for, [company X] will always be my customer.' • Salespeople don't always embrace new products because it jeopardizes the customer and, in turn, the salesperson's credibility with the customer. • Even if management is committed to selling new products, it is not clear if management is committed to supporting those new products for the customer.
OFDM-related findings	• Salespeople will at times get the impression that the organization has become too focused on directives to please a very few and lose sight of the true goal of making sales. • 'I realized my company wasn't ready to answer the questions that customer would ask, so I didn't mention the new product.'
SFDM-related findings	• Modification occurs if the directive threatens commissions. • 'Salespeople are like water; they find the path of least resistance.' • Salespeople will sometimes engage in self-destructive behavior to communicate to management how objectionable a directive is. • Salespeople sell to the compensation plan, making all other guidance subordinate. • Salespeople are aware of directives that make them less valuable to the organization. • Directives that increase monitoring and supervision often encounter resistance

consistent with what was suggested by the extant literature. These comments were often framed in the context of new product introductions where the necessary support was perceived to be lacking, forcing salespeople to modify directives in order to protect their customers, their firm and themselves.

Similarly, in relation to OFDM, examples were provided by respondents indicating the existence of this dimension of directive modification. The overarching theme here tended to be a perception that a company was being short-sighted in its suggested actions, which was jeopardizing sales. As suggested by the literature, the salesperson was taking actions to modify directives that, from the organization's perspective, may have beneficial long-term implications, but from the salesperson perspective could be injurious to short-term performance. It could be that respondents were framing this from the perspective of 'protecting the company' from itself deflecting attention from their desire to protect their personal interests. This may suggest a possible relationship between OFDM and SFDM; however, for the purposes of a robust articulation of the directive modification phenomenon, the dimension of OFDM was retained in our item generation and scale development.

In relation to SFDM, there are clear indications, as would be expected, that salespeople modify directives to protect their own interests. Further, there were a number of comments suggesting that means of minimizing effort in

relation to return were top-of-mind for salespeople when considering organizational directives. As noted by one of the respondents, 'Salespeople are like water; they will find the path of least resistance.' Further, it was clear that a focus upon sales/commissions was paramount in evaluating the influence of a directive. Modification of a directive appeared to be very likely to occur if commissions are threatened. Finally, salespeople also seemed likely to engage in modification if a directive threatened their eventual value to the organization. If the directive made the salesperson, 'easier to be replaced,' there was a clear self-interest motivation to modify the directive. (For instance, installation of sales force automation systems.)

In total, the salesperson interviews offered valuable reinforcement of the results of the previously reported literature review. This prompted the progression to the next stage of scale development, which was item generation.

Study 2: item generation

Based upon the results of Study 1 and the review of the literature, a pool of 21 semantic differential scale items was generated by the research team to assess the three types of directive modification previously discussed. [Appendix 2](#) includes a list of the 21 scale items. These 21 items consisted of three sets of seven similar items. A common opening phrase was used for each set to distinguish the intended dimension to be measured. So, the first set of

seven items began with the phrase, 'Compared to my individual goals, including those assigned by my employer (e.g. quotas) and those I have personally set for myself, I would treat the directive as...' in order to capture SFDM behavior. This opening phrase was then followed by each semantic differential scale item with different endpoints such as 'very important ... not important at all' and 'something to be circumvented ... something to be accepted.' After the respondent completed those seven items, a new opening phrase was applied to designate the next dimension and the same seven ending phrases from the previous set were repeated. This was done in the third set of items as well.

The semantic differential scale was chosen for two reasons. First, this scale type was selected as a means to prevent respondent fatigue on the survey. Second, a semantic differential scale is appropriate because of the somewhat affective nature of the phenomenon we are studying and the subjective nature of responses. Likert scales lend themselves to measuring the likelihood of a behavior with the behavior being an either-or proposition. We are attempting to measure how a boundary spanner might engage in the gray area between complete rejection and complete acceptance. A semantic differential scale more accurately portrays the personal prioritization of the directive among many options that a boundary spanner would experience in the given scenario.

The list of items was subjected to a review by a panel of five academic experts (two advanced stage doctoral students, two associate professors of marketing, one full professor of marketing, all working within the sales domain), as well as pre-tested on a group of sales students. Some of the specific wording was altered, but otherwise all items were retained to measure each type of directive modification.

Study 3A – initial item testing

Data were collected through an online survey of B2B sales agents. The sample consisted of a prescreened panel of volunteers from across the USA. An electronic survey company – US Sample, Inc. – facilitated contact with the respondents and helped to enlist their participation. Data collected through online panels has begun to appear regularly in many high-quality business journals (e.g. Darrat, Amyx, and Bennett 2010; Punj 2006). Although there are still opponents to its use, there are a number of advantages, such as access to a nationwide sample as well as improved data accuracy since the data are input electronically, thus removing some possibilities of coding errors by the researcher (Birnbau 2004). Additionally, comparison of online and paper-and-pencil data collections indicate similar covariance structures for both methods (Stanton 1998).

Respondents were offered a cash equivalent worth \$6.00 for their participation in this survey. Of the 4120

invitations sent, a total of 1036 panel members responded to the survey resulting in a response rate of 25.15%. Because the panel was not exclusively B2B salespeople, a qualifying question was asked to eliminate B2C salespeople, which left 406 responses. To assist in screening low involvement respondents, an item was inserted asking the respondent to leave the answer blank. Responses were also eliminated if the participant did not take a minimum amount of time to complete the survey. After these steps, a total of 304 usable responses remained for analysis with an effective response rate of 7.37%.

A scenario-based questionnaire was employed for this study. The application of scenario-based scales is an accepted practice when the goal of the scale is to capture a reaction or related values, goals, or intended actions of the individual respondent in relation to a situation (see Konig et al. 2007). The scenarios are provided in Appendix 3. Respondents were instructed to randomly choose the customer with whom they had most recently completed a sale. Then, a scenario was introduced, and the respondent was asked a number of questions to gauge how they would respond in such a situation. After the first scenario was introduced, a second, different scenario was introduced, and participants were asked the same set of questions based on this new scenario.

The scenarios utilized in this study describe a situation in which the parent organization has introduced a new product to the market and has directed its sales agents to prioritize promoting this product to all existing customers. In each scenario, one or more of the relevant parties (self, customer, or parent organization) is depicted as suffering some injurious effect from the new product. This was done to elicit different motivations for directive modification among participants.

A new product introduction was selected for a number of reasons. First, for most salespeople new product introductions are a commonly experienced directive. By utilizing a scenario that draws from salesperson past experiences, responses will be more representative of the reality of the salesperson function rather than being based on hypothetical intentions of respondents that may or may not be realistic. Second, a new product introduction scenario most accurately depicts a situation where directives can have mixed consequences for the boundary spanner irrespective of the long-term strategic potential for the firm. It is often in these contexts where supervisors are limited in their ability to assess how the salesperson is enacting the directive. New product introductions require some level of reliance by the selling organization on its sales force to receive and deliver on the directive. Third, a new product introduction directive presents the opportunity for a wide range of reactions by the salesperson. A salesperson can neglect the new product altogether, mention it in passing and advise the customer against it along with a host of other possible modifications. By using this scenario, we believe

we can more readily measure the continuum of modification intention possibilities, whereas many other scenarios would only allow for full acceptance or full rejection of the directive. Additionally, these scenarios can be readily combined or separated to achieve the necessary treatments for the current research.

Because respondents were asked to answer questions based on two scenarios independent of each other, a number of steps were taken to prevent cross-contamination effects. First, the order of the two scenarios introduced was randomized in order to prevent any order effects. Additionally, each scenario was exposed equally in combination with all other possible scenarios. So, scenario 1 appeared an equal number of times in conjunction with treatments 2, 3, 4, and 5.

Exploratory factor analysis

The 21 items were factor analyzed using the principal factor analysis method in the SAS software package. The principal factor analysis method was chosen over the maximum likelihood method because the data are not expected to be normally distributed. Two factor extraction methods were utilized to determine the number of factors to retain: the scree plot test and the percentage of variance method. These methods were chosen over the more commonly used Kaiser rule (eigenvalues > 1) because the Kaiser rule has shown to yield unreliable results and is more appropriate for principal components analysis (DeVellis 2003; Rizzo, House, and Lirtzman 1970). The scree plot test examines a graphical display of the eigenvalues of the factor analysis to search for the point at which the eigenvalues level off (Mallin and Pullins 2009). The percentage of variance method analyzes

the shared variance (communality) amongst the items to determine the common factors (Darmon 1987).

Utilizing the above extraction methods, an exploratory factor analysis with an oblique rotation was performed on the 21 items from the survey. These extraction methods and rotation were chosen because they allow the factors to be related to each other and result in some correlation between them (Hatcher 1994; Walsh and Beatty 2007). This initial test resulted in a five-factor solution. However, two of these factors indicated a low amount of variance explained, and the entire solution held a good deal of cross-loading of factors. The cross-loading variables were removed from the analysis. Once these items were removed, a clear three-factor solution emerged utilizing a total of nine items from the survey. Recall that the 21 items are a series of combinations of three opening phrases and seven ending phrases. The nine items that emerged from the factor analysis were the same three end phrases combined with the three opening phrases. Table 2 shows the items included in the final factor solution along with their factor loadings.

The results of the study strongly support the three dimensions of directive modification intention that we have set forth. Because the same three ending phrases emerged in each factor, we have substantial evidence that each dimension indicated by the opening phrases create a significant difference in the mind of the respondents. Further testing was conducted through a confirmatory analysis and an examination of scale validity.

Study 3B: confirmatory factor analysis and validity tests

In Study 3B, we seek to further confirm and validate a scale for empirically capturing the three distinct dimensions of

Table 2. Exploratory factor analysis results.

	Factor loading
<i>Factor 1: Self-focused directive modification intentions</i> Compared to my individual goals, including those assigned by my employer (e.g. quotas) and those I have personally set for myself, I would treat the directive to promote this product as...	
A rule to be broken.....A rule to be followed	0.60578
Something to be circumvented.....Something to be accepted	0.58006
A loose guideline.....A rule set in stone	0.64018
<i>Factor 2: Customer-focused directive modification intentions</i> Compared to my role as an advocate for this customer, I would treat the directive to promote this product as...	
A rule to be broken.....A rule to be followed	0.78768
Something to be circumvented.....Something to be accepted	0.80083
A loose guideline.....A rule set in stone	0.73971
<i>Factor 3: Organization-focused directive modification intentions</i> Compared to my role as an employee that looks out for the best interests of my organization, I would treat the directive to promote this product as...	
A rule to be broken.....A rule to be followed	0.81175
Something to be circumvented.....Something to be accepted	0.83019
A loose guideline.....A rule set in stone	0.79365

directive modification intentions (from within the same sample as Study 2). The 9-item, 3-factor structure that emerged in the exploratory factor analysis was submitted to a confirmatory factor analysis. An inspection of model fit revealed reasonable, if mixed, results. GFI is 0.8929, RMSEA is 0.1391, CFI is 0.9523, NNI is 0.9285, and χ^2 is 304.8931. Although the RMSEA is noticeably higher than the generally accepted cut-off of 0.08 (Hatcher 1994), other indices such as CFI and NNI indicate a good fit for the model. Additionally, each item loaded significantly on its designated factor.

To further test the legitimacy of our findings, a number of other validity tests were run on the factor analysis results. The composite reliability of each factor, factor loadings of each item in the model, and Cronbach's alpha are displayed in Table 3. The numbers indicate that the three dimensions are reliable and that each item significantly loads onto its dimension. The composite reliability for each factor exceeds 0.918, well above the generally accepted minimum of 0.7 (Fornell and Larcker 1981; Hatcher 1994).

Content validity and construct validity were used as the criteria for determining the validity of the scale aimed at capturing directive modification (Ping 2004). Construct validity is composed of two parts: discriminant validity and convergent validity. Based on the high inter-item correlations, the proposed measures for directive modification appear to be content valid.

Discriminant validity was tested in two ways. First, a chi-square difference test was conducted (Anderson and Gerbing 1988). The chi-square of the standard measure-

ment model in which all factors are allowed to co-vary was compared to the chi-square of measurement models in which the correlation between two of the factors was fixed. This test was run for each possible pair of factors. In each instance, the difference between chi-square values for the standard model and modified model were significant at the $p < 0.001$ level, indicating discriminant validity. Second, the factors were subjected to a variance extracted test in which the average variance extracted for two factors is compared to the square of the correlation between them (Fornell and Larcker 1981). For each possible pairing, the variance extracted of both variables exceeded the squared correlation between them, also suggesting discriminant validity.

Convergent validity was subjected to multiple analytical tests as well. First, the average variance extracted of each dimension was calculated. Each of these values exceeded the recommended 0.50 threshold, signifying that the measure explains significantly more variance than does measurement error (Fornell and Larcker 1981). This indicates convergent validity. Additionally, the t -tests for each factor loading were assessed. In all cases, the calculated t -values were 26.5929 or higher also suggesting convergent validity.

Study 3 provides strong evidence confirming the strength of the directive modification measurement items. Although the confirmatory factor analysis yielded some inconsistent findings, the rest of the tests provide robust results supporting the validity of the three proposed dimensions.

Table 3. Composite reliability (CR), Average variance extracted (AVE), and factor loadings.

	CR	AVE	Cronbach's Alpha	Factor loading
<i>Factor 1: Self-focused directive modification intentions</i> Compared to my individual goals, including those assigned by my employer (e.g. quotas) and those I have personally set for myself, I would treat the directive to promote this product as...	0.918	0.898	0.922	
A rule to be broken.....A rule to be followed				0.8928
Something to be circumvented.....Something to be accepted				0.8981
A loose guideline.....A rule set in stone				0.8708
<i>Factor 2: Customer-focused directive modification intentions</i> Compared to my role as an advocate for this customer, I would treat the directive to promote this product as...	0.936	0.923	0.939	
A rule to be broken.....A rule to be followed				0.9225
Something to be circumvented.....Something to be accepted				0.9041
A loose guideline.....A rule set in stone				0.9025
<i>Factor 3: Organization-focused directive modification intentions</i> Compared to my role as an employee that looks out for the best interests of my organization, I would treat the directive to promote this product as...	0.935	0.923	0.939	
A rule to be broken.....A rule to be followed				0.9075
Something to be circumvented.....Something to be accepted				0.9065
A loose guideline.....A rule set in stone				0.9167

Study 3C: nomological test

The validation of the directive modification phenomenon and the contribution of these three dimensions of directive modification to marketing research is further established by investigating its relationship to constructs within the bounds of core theory. In association with cognitive dissonance predictions, we have selected relationship importance and organizational commitment as key antecedent variables, and job satisfaction as a key dependent variable for testing the nomological validity of directive modification intentions. As noted by Burnes and James (1995), dissonance related to organizational initiatives for behavioral change is much more likely to occur when employees view affected behaviors as being highly important. In association with this, we have selected a salesperson's view of customer relationship importance as one focal antecedent. Similarly, an employee's level of commitment to his/her organization is indicative of the importance placed upon such a relationship. The more committed a sales employee is to his/her organization, the more likely is dissonance/resistance to result from suggested changes that an employee may see as potentially problematic (cf., Burnes and James 1995). Job satisfaction was selected as a relevant dependent variable not only because of its potential to relate to actions taken to ease feelings of dissonance (Lii 2001), but also because of its prevalence in salesperson research (e.g., Johnson and Sohi 2014).

CFDM stems from a desire to sustain and nurture the relationship with a customer because of the value of that relationship. It stands to reason that an important customer relationship to a boundary spanner would create an increased willingness to engage in CFDM, especially when such a directive is dissonance-creating (Burnes and James 1995). Additionally, we can assume that a relationship that is important to the boundary spanner will by extension also be important to the organization employing the boundary spanner. This would create a motivation to engage in OFDM by the boundary spanner. Formally:

H1: Customer relationship importance will positively affect (a) customer-focused directive modification intentions and (b) organization-focused directive modification intentions.

On the other hand, the importance of the relationship with the customer would not logically have any direct bearing on the motivation of the boundary spanner to engage in SFDM. Again, we anticipate that the self-interests of the boundary spanner will be expressed indirectly through the interests of the customer rather than directly (i.e., the focus is upon the well-being of the customer). Therefore, we would expect the importance of the relationship with a customer to have no influence on SFDM behaviors.

In relation to organizational commitment, extant literature indicates that commitment to the parent organization is a positive and significant predictor of an employee

engaging in 'extra-role' behaviors that go beyond expected behaviors to benefit his/her organization (O'Reilly and Chatman 1986; Schappe 1998). Such behaviors would become especially relevant to an employee if s/he perceives an action to be potentially harmful to the organization (via dissonance – Bacharach, Bamberger, and Sonnenstuhl 1996). A boundary spanner engaging in OFDM is motivated to either save face for the parent organization or assist other constituents within the parent organization. In this case, the boundary spanning employee is using his/her own discretion, is not being directly rewarded for the behavior, and is attempting to improve organizational function of the employer. Given this, we expect a positive relationship between commitment to the parent organization and OFDM. No prediction is made relative to either SFDM or CFDM.

H2: Organizational commitment will positively affect organization-focused directive modification intentions.

In relation to a job satisfaction outcome, dissonance theory would predict when employees take actions that are consistent with their beliefs and values (i.e., that reduce feelings of dissonance), the outcome is a positive effect upon job satisfaction (Lii 2001). Additionally, modification can be a form of compromise between conflicting demands. If, for example, the interests of the customer are not best served by strict adherence to a directive, the salesperson may seek some compromise (modification of the directive) to resolving the conflict. So, directive modification can serve to lessen role conflict. Consistent with this, we predict that sales employees who express directive modification intentions will feel more positive about their job, enhancing feelings of job satisfaction.

H3: All forms of directive modification intentions will positively affect employee job satisfaction.

To test the nomological validity of the three proposed dimensions of directive modification, we used the same data collection discussed in Study 3A and B. As a part of the questionnaire, each participant was asked items regarding their job satisfaction (Nygaard and Dahlstrom 2002; Rizzo, House, and Lirtzman 1970) as well as the importance of the relationship (Morgan and Hunt 1994; Mowday, Steers, and Porter 1979) with the focal customer that was randomly chosen during the survey and the salesperson's commitment to his/her organization (Mowday, Steers, and Porter 1979). Each respondent was asked to answer questions regarding two scenarios that he/she were to treat as unrelated. This creates a repeated measures data collection with a within-subjects and a between-subjects factor. Given this design, a mixed model was chosen to test the nomological validity of the three dimensions of directive modification because there is the potential for both fixed and random effects.

Mixed models are more flexible and robust than traditional regression or structural equation models because

they incorporate the influence of both fixed and random effects that may emerge due to the repeated measures design of the survey. By accounting for a portion of the error variance in a fixed-effects model, a mixed model can be expected to produce 'more efficient estimates and more powerful tests.' (Mowday, Steers, and Porter 1979, 13) Additionally, mixed effects models are more effective at handling unbalanced designs and lead to more detailed coefficient estimates by utilizing the maximum likelihood method. The SAS programming language was used to test the mixed model. The procedure PROC MIXED was utilized to account for the random effects that could be caused by the different pairings of scenarios.

Figures 1 and 2 depict the tested relationships as well as the results of mixed model analyses. Relationship importance is a significant predictor of the level of CFDM as well as OFDM (supporting H1 a and b). However, relationship importance is not a significant predictor of SFDM. In relation to organizational commitment, all three forms of directive modification are positively affected by an employee's commitment to his/her organization (supporting H2, but finding additional significant relationships that were not predicted). While the relationships with CFDM and SFDM were not hypothesized, they are not unreasonable. The commitment of the individual to the organization is within the information context of that salesperson, which includes personal goals set by the organization (e.g. quotas). Therefore, higher commitment would indicate a greater willingness on the part of the salesperson to do what s/he interprets as best for the organization including breaking the rules (even if the organization itself issued those rules). Additionally, all three forms of directive modification have a positive effect upon job satisfaction (supporting H3).

Discussion

Managerial contribution

This research has a number of managerial implications. First, conceptualization of directive modification intentions demonstrates the importance of understanding a salesperson's customer-focused motivation for directive modification. When management is contemplating behavior-focused and behavior controlling changes among the salesforce, understanding that one of the primary drivers of salesperson acceptance will likely be the effect upon his/her customer allows for management to possess a better understanding of how effective 'positioning' must be developed to encourage salesperson adoption. Such findings are consistent with the work in organizational behavior where organizational change initiatives are much more likely to be successful when employees are highly involved in the change process and are, as a result, less likely to experience cognitive dissonance and resist the change initiatives (Bacharach, Bamberger, and Sonnenstuhl 1996). Further, such understanding will put management in a better

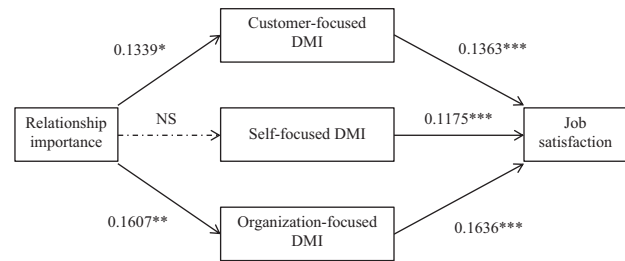


Figure 1. Nomological testing of directive modification intentions. *Significant at p -value < 0.1; **Significant at p -value < 0.05; ***Significant at p -value < 0.01.

position to actually predict which salespeople will be most likely to accept versus reject the directive, given the anticipated influence upon the specific salesperson's customer(s). A possible implication of new directives or attempts to control salesperson behaviors is the extent to which mandated behaviors place salespeople in awkward, conflicted or dissonant situations with their customers. This may be particularly salient in instances where salespeople have long-standing relationships with customers. It is in these customer contexts where new directives may be viewed as potentially jeopardizing salesperson-customer trust (particularly in cases of new, untried products/services) thereby placing salespeople in precarious positions of conflicting motives. Management might seek to provide the sales staff with the opportunity to phase in new directives permitting salespeople the ability to test new applications in select (controlled) contexts where clients are better prepared to adapt the new application. Similarly, by introducing the new directives among a smaller percentage of a salesperson's total business, management permits them the opportunity to more closely monitor any implications of the change thereby diminishing potential conflict imposed by new directives. (These challenges may be less prevalent among salespeople with shorter tenure and/or fewer established clients in their sales portfolio.)

Second, findings from the current study of directive modification behavior suggest that managers may,

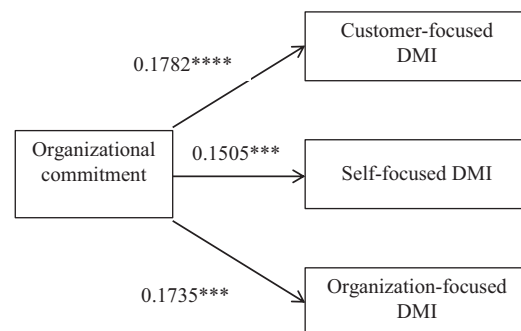


Figure 2. Organizational commitment and directive modification intentions. *Significant at p -value < 0.1; **Significant at p -value < 0.05; ***Significant at p -value < 0.01.

surprisingly, wish to permit or even encourage some forms of this behavior in particular circumstances and conditions. Until now, deviation from organizationally prescribed actions has generally been discouraged. However, we have empirically verified that different motivations for directive modification exist based on the interests of the boundary spanner him-/herself, the external partner(s), or the organization. In instances where boundary spanners are engaging in directive modification on behalf of the organization or customer (and in some instances the salesperson him-/herself), then it may be in the best interests of the organization to introduce strategies that can tolerate modification behavior within the bounds of professional, policy, legal and ethical boundaries. Given the positive linkage from organizational commitment to each form of directive modification, it seems it would be important to understand the perspective of the salesperson to gain deeper insights into why the modification may be perceived as a 'helping' behavior.

Similarly, directive modification could be considered by managers as a form of double-loop learning. Individuals engaged in double-loop learning adapt and potentially question the efficacy of goals that are set before them (Argyris and Schon 1978). This type of learning is probably the more difficult for organizations to achieve (Argyris 1991), even though it has been linked to a stronger relationship orientation in organizations (Chaston, Badger, and Sadler-Smith 2000). With many organizations seeking a relationship orientation from their boundary spanning employees, directive modification may be a positive signal to management. In short, directive modification in the instance of salesperson self-interest can have positive benefits for a firm and should be carefully assessed and managed to assure that the firm's best interests are being served.

On a related note, this research may also influence the level of specificity of organizational directives in various situations. If an organization feels it would benefit from its boundary spanners engaging in directive modification as a result of that employee's tacit knowledge, it may seek to set forth directives that create more of a framework for boundary spanner behavior rather than a highly specific directive. By doing so, the boundary spanner is allowed some flexibility to find the best alternative for the customer (and possibly organization) while still pursuing the employer's desired general strategic outcome.

The downside implications of tolerating, if not systematically anticipating, directive modification is the impact of these practices on the ability of the firm to effectively measure the performance of strategic initiatives. Given the potential propensity of salespeople to have higher incidence of directive modification with their larger accounts, the magnitude of the performance-impact of these modification behaviors on the firm's newly initiated strategies is possibly even greater. Platforms for initiating changes that permit multiple options can be configured in a manner

that permits performance measurement and ultimately the establishment of dashboards. One possibility would be to vet proposed changes among the sales force in advance to identify application, service, financing and other implementation strategy challenges inclusive of possible alternative core product offerings (again, adding dissonance reducing steps to the implementation process). Careful preparation by firms in advance of new initiatives, when they are prone to be vulnerable to directive modification, can result in more effectively ascertaining the likely success of strategic deployments (Bacharach, Bamberger, and Sonnenstuhl 1996).

Future research implications

This study also contains a number of significant research implications. The current research expands our understanding of boundary spanner behavior. In the extant literature, employee deviation from organizationally prescribed actions is primarily treated as self-interested behavior that is detrimental to the organization (e.g. Ball, Trevino, and Sims 1994; Lawrence and Robinson 2007; Perrone, Zaheer, and McEvily 2003). However, a stream of literature has recently emerged that explores the notion of deviation from organizational directives by employees as a possible benefit to the organization (Parks, Ma, and Gallagher 2010). Directive modification extends this new stream of literature to explore the unique situations faced by boundary spanners. By overlapping agency theory and cognitive dissonance, we consider a number of motivations that contribute to boundary spanner directive modification intentions, especially in relation to attempted control of employee behaviors. Not only is the distinction of customer-, organization-, and SFDM argued as important from a multi-theoretic perspective, it is also empirically supported in our data collection.

Capturing the nature of directive modification behaviors is valuable to firms as it enables them to identify salesperson systematic and idiosyncratic behaviors. Future supervision and strategic formulation should seek to accommodate these behaviors (presuming they are ultimately in the best interest of the firm). Modification behaviors can prove to be a valuable source of information. Sales cultures that encourage information about client management behavior (compliant or not) have a much greater likelihood of gathering data that may expose directive modification behavior which could be particularly valuable in instances of systematic deviance.

Limitations

As a first step in conceptualizing and measuring the phenomenon of directive modification, this study is not without its limitations. First, the scenarios utilized in the current research are negatively framed. While this is in

keeping with the base assumption of directive modification that the boundary spanner disagrees with the directive in some way, it does constrain the generalizability of our findings. It must be considered that the level of disagreement (potentially influenced by the wording of the provided scenario) could have some influence on the intentions to modify directives. Also, our scenarios are related to a new product introduction. There may be some aspects of that specific context that influence our findings as well.

While this study sought to identify and validate an observed phenomenon in sales management, other variables of interest could be investigated in relation to a theoretically valid nomological net. For example, dissonance theory would predict such things as employee trust of his/her organization or employee ethical views of the directed behaviors could certainly influence intentions to engage in directive modification. Further, effects upon such behaviors as employee performance from engaging in directive modification need to be investigated. Identification of the distinctive nature of these constructs within the complex motivation and performance systems that characterize the sales organization is beyond the scope of this study but merits further attention. This enhancement to the sales literature may be particularly important because the evidence in this study suggests that customer directive modification may be motivated from a positive outcome focused intention where the non-compliant motivations previously studied have failed to capture firm and customer empathetic motivations of salesperson deviance.

Lastly, while our focus was on salespeople, there is certainly reason to believe that field sales managers most directly responsible for overseeing the sales force (represented by the sample in this study) may be enablers of directive modification. When the reality of a firm strategy hits the challenges of field deployment, evidence may be quickly accumulated regarding the viability of the new initiative and, if so, how best to modify it for optimal effectiveness. To presume that management at the field sales level is not aware and potentially enabling these modifications would be naive. How best to capture this phenomenon and whether the field salesperson construct developed in this study is a suitable measure of field sales management directive modification (and/or enablement) could prove to be a promising future investigation.

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Appendix 1: Qualitative interviews basic script:

I am interested in discussing policies and directives from management toward the sales force that you as a salesperson don't necessarily agree with. Kind of asking 'Do you do everything you're told to do, and why do you not do all that you are told to do?' These can be new ones or ones that you have dealt with for years.

- Do you have any stories when you or others have done this?
- How did the sales force in general respond to the directive?
- What were the primary motivations behind the salesperson behavior?
- What do you think is management's stance on this reaction?
- Does it help if you know how the directive or policy will help the organization or is self-interest the only real concern?
- Does it matter if the directive is reactive or proactive in nature?
- Are you ever concerned that your company may start contacting your customer without you?
- Do you ever try to protect customers from these directives?
- Do you ever try to protect your company from itself?
- With respect to customers, what level of ownership did you have with the customers you sold to?
- Were they 'your' customer or 'your employer's' customers? Does that answer change depending on the customer?
- Did that ownership ever influence what kind of things you did for the customer?
- If you company gives you a lot of autonomy, does that make you want to do better for the company or does it make it tempting to take advantage of that?
- Are salespeople concerned with being recognized by their firm?
- Do salespeople ever go against company policy just to do it their own way and be unique?
- Any further thoughts on this topic that my questions did not address?

Appendix 2: Directive modification intentions

Compared to my *individual goals*, including those assigned by my employer (e.g. quotas) and those I have personally set for myself, I would treat the directive as...

A high priority	_____	A low priority
Very Important	_____	Not important at all
A rule to be broken	_____	A rule to be followed
Something to be circumvented	_____	Something to be accepted
A loose guideline	_____	A rule set in stone
A rule that should be adapted to my current behavior	_____	A rule that will change my current behavior
A rule to be followed <i>after</i> everything else is done	_____	A rule that comes <i>before</i> everything else

Compared to my role as an *advocate for this customer*, I would treat the directive as...

A high priority	_____	A low priority
Very Important	_____	Not important at all
A rule to be broken	_____	A rule to be followed
Something to be circumvented	_____	Something to be accepted
A loose guideline	_____	A rule set in stone
A rule that should be adapted to my current behavior	_____	A rule that will change my current behavior
A rule to be followed <i>after</i> everything else is done	_____	A rule that comes <i>before</i> everything else

Compared to my role as an employee that looks out for the best interests of my organization, I would treat the directive as...

A high priority	_____	A low priority
Very Important	_____	Not important at all
A rule to be broken	_____	A rule to be followed
Something to be circumvented	_____	Something to be accepted
A loose guideline	_____	A rule set in stone
A rule that should be adapted to my current behavior	_____	A rule that will change my current behavior
A rule to be followed <i>after</i> everything else is done	_____	A rule that comes <i>before</i> everything else

Appendix 3: Individual scenarios

Background Information and Instructions (Included with all scenarios)

Please read the following paragraph and base your answers to the remaining questions on how you would react in each given scenario.

Suppose your employer has decided to add a new product to the portfolio of products the sales force sells. This new product is related to your organization's current industry, but it is not a direct extension of an existing product line. There is uncertainty as to whether this new product represents a permanent shift in the industry or if it is a trend that will be replaced in about five years. Management has repeatedly emphasized that all salespeople must heavily promote this product to all existing customers as well as any new customer contacts. A quota has been set with respect to this new product, but you do not feel it will be challenging to achieve. This new product has a commission potential similar to the other products that you currently sell, so there is not significant financial motivation for selling this new product over other products. The training on this product is done individually, therefore you have not had a chance to discuss this new product with any other salespeople in your company.

Customer Inequity Scenario

After your training on the product, you start to believe that the product is probably not going to be beneficial for your customer (the one you identified earlier in this survey). The problem is that the product would be difficult and potentially costly for your customer to adopt, and it would only deliver marginal results for them. You feel that you could convince them to purchase this product, but you are fairly certain it will cause them headaches internally in the future.

Organization Inequity Scenario

After your training on the product, you start to believe that your organization may not have thoroughly refined this product. In your opinion, then product has some basic flaws that will possibly cause unintended consequences when put into 'real-life' use. Additionally, your company has instituted a generous return policy for this new product, and items returned due to defect do not negatively impact your commission from the original sale. So, promoting this new product will likely cost your organization money because of the potentially high number of returns. You are confident that your customer would not be upset with you if the product had to be returned.

Self-inequity Scenario

You believe that this product will be difficult for you to effectively sell. The amount of information that you need to be able to provide to each of your clients is going to be time-consuming for you to generate. You estimate that selling this new product will create an additional — four to five hours of work for you each week beyond your normal work week.